

AN INFECTIOUS CAUSE

AIDS gets a metaphorical treatment in this volume of dispatches from twilight zones of suffering

AIDS SUTRA: UNTOLD STORIES FROM INDIA
by SALMAN RUSHDIE, KIRAN DESAI, WILLIAM DALRYMPLE AND OTHERS
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■ By Sunil Sethi

The HIV/AIDS story in India is full of strange and savage contradictions. For years, there was quibbling about the approximate number suffering from it. Figures veered wildly between 20 million and five million until the National Family Health Survey (2005-06) confirmed a realistic estimate of between two and three million. The patients are concentrated in certain states and districts and among high risk groups—sex workers, drug users, truckers among others. Indian drug companies have taken the lead in reducing the cost of anti-retroviral drugs, yet a combination of poor delivery, erratic usage and social stigma have failed to substantially bring down the numbers. In his introductory arguments, Amartya Sen cites ignorance as the “punishing” factor of the waste of human potential in a country with the third largest population living with HIV/AIDS.

Promoted as “India’s first charity book” (a proportion of each copy purchased will go to support affected children), the publisher together with the Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation commissioned 16 well-known writers and journalists to travel to destinations far and near and tell the stories of those affected. What emerges is a loosely arranged composite of suffering in the twilight zone, with each devastating slice of Indian reality intensified by the writer’s perception.

Kiran Desai and William Dalrymple explore the lives of descendants of Devadasis in Andhra Pradesh and Karna-

taka; Sunil Gangopadhyay records the changing face of Kolkata’s old red light district Sonagachhi; Vikram Seth excavates a poem he wrote about AIDS long ago; and Amit Chaudhuri talks to several Mumbai doctors, who selflessly withstood the tide of medical ostracism in the early days.

Some writers are better equipped than others to handle situations among gender benders. One can sense small stifled gasps of surprise as Salman Rushdie encounters the complexities of *hijra* life in Mumbai, and Mukul Kesavan the gradations of MSMS (men who have sex with men) in Bangalore. At an NGO demo at which *hijras* are taught how to apply paan-flavoured condoms on simulated

MARGINAL LIVES: Sex workers of Sonagachhi, Kolkata’s red light area

penises, Rushdie wryly notes: “I was given a couple of impressively swift and skilful demonstrations of the technique, on, I hasten to add, the wooden members only”.

In what may seem a 3-D view (destitution, despair, desperation) of the bleak interstices of Indian life, a few stories stand out. Nikita Lalwani’s encounter with Dr Tokugha, the Naga doctor who was unwittingly infected by a blood donation, exposes the ignorance of Indian courts about HIV/AIDS. Were it not for his lawyer’s contention that the right to marry is a fundamental human right, the Supreme Court’s judgement against partnerships among HIV/AIDS patients would have gone unchallenged. Siddhartha Deb’s journey in Manipur, simply told with controlled detail, is an account of India marooned: years of insurgency, military presence and free flow of drugs have driven its young, jobless population to heroin addiction, contracting HIV/AIDS through shared syringes.

Sonia Faleiro unravels the intricate nexus between Mumbai’s streetwalkers and cops with gritty frames of film noir. The cat-and-mouse game of trading favours has resulted in a sizeable section of the city’s police force to become infected. But the best story is Aman Sethi’s highway trek with truckers: with a sardonic eye, he pierces the nocturnal world of long distance drivers and sex workers on the move, carrying the virus to every corner. Here is a clash between mean streets and modern highways, clutch gearshift and power steering, drunken drivers and corrupt checkpoints—and billions of rupees down the drain each year due to delayed or pilfered cargo. Proponents of India Shining will be swiftly transported to the Dark Ages. In a brilliant anthology, he deserves the first prize. ■

